need any prompting, and was back in Tawang in a flash. This was an excellent opportunity to experience the conditions (it was October) and go over the ground on which the battle had been fought by 5 Assam Rifles and 1 Sikh. Though I wasn't properly acclimatized, fortunately, I had little trouble on Bum-la other than the mandatory headache. As soon as we dropped down to Tawang, which is at 10,000 feet, that too disappeared and I went off to find Tashi Sonam again. It was ironical that the old man could not remember our earlier meeting a few months previously, but could recall dates and figures from fifty-sixty years ago without having to refer to any notes. He wanted to go over all the ground we had covered the last time, step by step, but I was in a hurry, so I repeatedly tried to steer him to the two events I was interested in. What happened in 1942 and then in 1950? He would have none of it though, and proceeded at his own pace. Finally, he came around to 1942. 'I was a young boy then,' said the former IB operative, 'but I subsequently joined one of my uncles who marched at the head of the Tibetan column when it came over Tse-la and Posheng-la to Dirang. I did odd jobs in the camp and was quite popular with the soldiers, who would play and joke with me all the time. Where they went and what they did, I had no idea, but I knew quite a few of them after a few days.'

Much later, when working for the IB, it became obvious to Tashi Sonam why the Tibetan Army had come. They knew the boundary treaty had been signed with Britain in 1913, and any concessions on Tawang which was on the Indian side of the line would be difficult as the British were very powerful and determined. Around mid-1942, there was a chance that the momentum of the Japanese invasion would extend through Burma into Assam. Suddenly, cracks had begun to emerge in the Asian mind about British supremacy, and for the watching Tibetans, should Japan be the new masters of Assam, it was necessary to have Tibetan troops present on the ground. The invasion of Tawang, therefore had little or nothing to do with Tawang itself. The objective was to get as far south as possible. In the event of a fresh boundary being drawn up with Imperial Japan, Tibet wanted in on what till just a few years previously was known as 'unadministered area'. Once it became apparent that they could not get across the Naga-Patkai and the Arakan Hills, the Tibetans quietly withdrew.

Tashi Sonam was popular with the Tibetan soldiers, and in later years had maintained his contact with a couple of them. Twenty years later, after the Nam Ka Chu and the Bum-la battles, the Chinese captured Tawang. Though the Chinese were quite averse to pandering to the lamas, the Chinese commanders decided to visit the main Tawang Monastery. Tashi Sonam and other prominent people were present in the monastery where the Chinese were welcomed as honoured guests and were presented scarves by the abbot. Usually it was never easy to identify who were the important Chinese officials. Present with the Chinese commander were a handful of Tibetans. Tashi Sonam recognized one of them—he had been a part of the Tibetan Army in 1942. Twice more in the next few days, Tashi Sonam was to see the Chinese commander. On both occasions, the former soldier was always part of the accompanying group.